

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 3 of 6 — Rebuilding

Postpartum Week 16

A widely available vitamin doing steady metabolic work.

Weekly nourishment theme

Vitamin B6, supporting protein use, nerves, and blood cells

“A widely available vitamin doing steady metabolic work.”

Why it matters now

Vitamin B6 helps your body use protein for energy and tissue repair, build the chemical messengers your nervous system relies on, and make hemoglobin, the part of your red blood cells that carries oxygen. It's involved in more than a hundred everyday enzyme reactions, most of them tied to how your body handles protein.

Your daily reference: ICMR-NIN's confirmed figure for adult women is 1.9 mg a day (EAR 1.6 mg), though the primary source doesn't show a separate pregnancy or breastfeeding figure. NIH's US reference does: 1.3 mg a day for other adult women, 1.9 mg during pregnancy, and 2.0 mg while breastfeeding — the highest life-stage figure for this vitamin. Rather than trying to hit an exact number, aim for a vitamin B6 source at most meals.

If you are breastfeeding or expressing milk: If you are breastfeeding or expressing milk, the NIH reference is slightly higher because vitamin B6 is supplied through breast milk in addition to supporting your own metabolism.

If you are not breastfeeding: If you're not breastfeeding, vitamin B6 remains important for your own energy metabolism and nervous system — your daily reference returns to the general adult figure.

Where vitamin B6 comes from: Vitamin B6 is genuinely well distributed across both plant and animal foods. Chickpeas are actually one of the richest single sources — even more concentrated per serving than most meat or fish — alongside fish, poultry, potatoes, bananas, and fortified cereals. A vegetarian day can meet this need through ordinary foods such as chickpeas, potatoes, nuts, seeds and fortified cereals, especially when these sources are included deliberately across the day.

A gentle note for this week: Authorities use different upper limits for vitamin B6. The older US upper limit is 100 mg a day for adults, while a newer European review set a much lower limit of 12 mg a day. Ordinary unfortified food is not associated with vitamin B6 nerve toxicity. The concern is supplemental B6, especially when several products — such as a multivitamin, magnesium supplement, B-complex or fortified drink — are combined. Do not add a separate high-dose B6 supplement unless your clinician has advised it. Stop the supplement and seek medical advice if you develop unexplained tingling, burning or numbness in your hands or feet.

This week's rhythm: A vitamin B6 source at most meals — chickpeas, fish, chicken, potatoes, or fortified cereal — adds up more reliably than trying to concentrate it into one meal.

Each day below offers two options, and both are built to carry this week's nutrient — you don't need to mix and match to get a genuine vitamin B6 source. Choose whichever suits you today — there's no 'right' path between A and B.

If you are managing a health condition

- **Thyroid condition:** There's no known clinically significant interaction between vitamin B6 and thyroid medicines — ordinary food and typical supplement use don't need special spacing.
- **Kidney disease:** Vitamin B6 status can sometimes run low in kidney disease, but this does not mean you should supplement independently. Your renal plan may also modify foods used frequently this week — including bananas, potatoes, tomatoes, dairy and legumes — depending on your potassium, phosphorus and protein needs. Follow your renal team's food and supplement guidance rather than using the general meal chart unchanged.

- High blood pressure or previous pre-eclampsia: Vitamin B6 status has been observed to run lower in some pregnancies affected by pre-eclampsia, but this is an association, not a treatment — it isn't a reason to self-supplement. Continue your prescribed monitoring and medicines as usual.
- Diabetes, recent gestational diabetes, or PCOS: Vitamin B6 does not require a special diet, but use the carbohydrate portions and meal pattern already advised for you. Keep fruit whole, pair it with protein or nuts where practical, and avoid automatically combining several starches — such as rice plus potato plus fruit — in one eating moment.

Day 1 — Anchor

Vitamin B6 helps your body use protein and build the chemical messengers your nervous system relies on. Both choices below carry a real source, not just one of them.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Besan cheela (chickpea-flour pancake) with a glass of milk.
- B. Vegetable-and-paneer paratha with a small bowl of curd and a side of green peas.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a chana (chickpea) curry and a small salad.
- B. A curry made with a locally available fish from the lower-mercury category, with rice and a potato or green-peas side.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A banana with a small handful of mixed nuts.
- B. Roasted chana chaat with cucumber and mint.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Dal, roti, pumpkin sabzi and a small roasted-peanut or sunflower-seed side.
- B. Chicken curry (cooked through) with rice and a potato sabzi.

If you're still hungry: Whatever's easiest to reach for right now.

Day 2 — A slightly higher need while breastfeeding

Vitamin B6's recommended intake is highest while breastfeeding of any adult life stage — a small but real increase worth understanding.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable daliya (cracked wheat) with a glass of milk and a spoon of wheat germ stirred in.
- B. Masala scrambled paneer (bhurji-style) with whole-wheat toast and a mixed-vegetable side.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a rajma (kidney bean) curry and a small bowl of curd.
- B. Mutton curry (cooked through) with rice and a sweet-potato sabzi.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Roasted chana with guava.
- B. A small bowl of curd with sunflower seeds and a spoon of roasted chana.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal, roti, a spinach sabzi, and a side of roasted peanuts.
- B. Chicken curry (cooked through) with rice and a green-peas side.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

About your prenatal or postnatal supplement: Vitamin B6 appears in many prenatal, postnatal, B-complex, magnesium and multivitamin products. Check all your labels together, because the amounts can add up. If your usual supplement already contains B6, do not add another B6 product solely for this week's theme.

Day 3 — Where vitamin B6 naturally shows up

Chickpeas, fish, poultry, potatoes, and fortified cereal all contribute — worth knowing which ordinary foods are actually doing the work, since it isn't only an animal-food story.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Aloo (potato) paratha with a small bowl of curd and a side of cabbage sabzi.
- B. Grilled chicken sandwich on whole-wheat bread with a bell-pepper-and-cucumber salad.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a rajma (kidney bean) curry, and a small bowl of cooked jowar (sorghum) on the side.
- B. A curry made with a locally available fish from the lower-mercury category, with rice and a cauliflower sabzi.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Roasted peanuts or pistachios with guava.
- B. Curd with one tablespoon of toasted wheat germ and apple or pear.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Dal, roti, a pumpkin (kaddu) sabzi, and a side of cauliflower.
- B. Mutton curry (cooked through) with rice and a cabbage sabzi.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

Day 4 — Beyond food: mood, medicines, and B6

Two things worth knowing this week that aren't about the meal chart at all — what the evidence really says about B6 and mood, and which everyday medicines can affect your B6 status.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Besan-and-vegetable dhokla (steamed chickpea-flour cake) with a glass of milk.
- B. Chicken keema with whole-wheat paratha and a mixed-vegetable side.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a chana (chickpea) curry and a cooked spinach side.
- B. Paneer-and-green-peas curry with rice and a mixed-vegetable salad.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Cottage cheese (paneer) cubes with a banana.
- B. A small bowl of curd with sunflower seeds and raisins.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal, roti, a pumpkin sabzi, and a side of cabbage.
- B. Rajma (kidney bean) curry with rice and a spinach side.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

About mood and B6: You may have heard vitamin B6 can help with mood or PMS-type symptoms. The evidence is real but genuinely mixed and mostly from small or lower-quality studies, so it isn't a strong enough basis for self-treating low mood with high-dose supplements. If mood is a real concern for you right now, that's worth raising with your care team directly, not managing through a vitamin. If low mood is persistent, worsening, or affecting your ability to function or care for yourself, contact your healthcare provider. Seek urgent local help if you have thoughts of harming yourself or your baby.

About medicines and B6: Certain long-term medicines can affect your vitamin B6 status — this includes some antiepileptic medicines (such as valproic acid, carbamazepine, or phenytoin), the antibiotic cycloserine, and theophylline for asthma. If you take any of these regularly, ask your care team whether you need anything beyond food and your usual multivitamin, rather than adding a high-dose B6 supplement on your own.

Day 5 — Away from home

Roasted chana, mixed nuts, or a bowl of curd are easy, portable ways to keep this week's focus going on a busy day.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. A pre-made peanut-butter-and-banana sandwich, carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten.
- B. A pre-made chicken sandwich, made with fully cooked chicken, carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. A chana (chickpea) and vegetable wrap, carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten.
- B. A mutton roll, made with fully cooked mutton, carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten, with a mixed-vegetable side.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Roasted peanuts and sunflower seeds, kept portable.
- B. A small bowl of curd, kept in an insulated bag with an ice pack and kept cold until eaten, with sunflower seeds and raisins.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. A reheated rajma-and-vegetable curry with rice.
- B. Paneer, green-peas and potato curry with roti.

If you're still hungry: Whatever's already within reach.

Food safety: Keep the sandwiches, wrap, roll, and curd all refrigerated or in an insulated bag with an ice pack, and make sure they stay cold until you actually eat them — discard anything that's been sitting out at room temperature for more than about two hours (about one hour in hot weather). Reheat the rajma curry or paneer curry until steaming hot before eating.

Day 6 — Small, steady habits continue

Same idea as the past few weeks — one dependable vitamin B6 source most meals, whether that's chickpeas, fish, chicken, or a rajma-and-seed pairing, placed steadily through your week.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable poha with a banana on the side.
- B. A whole-wheat fish sandwich or wrap made with fully cooked fish from a locally available lower-mercury category, with cucumber or another familiar vegetable.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a rajma (kidney bean) curry, and roasted sunflower seeds on the side.
- B. Paneer-and-green-peas curry with whole-wheat roti and a cabbage sabzi.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Roasted peanuts with raisins.
- B. A small bowl of curd with about two tablespoons of sunflower seeds.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Dal, roti, a spinach sabzi, and a side of cauliflower.
- B. Chicken curry with rice and a cooked mixed-vegetable side.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

Day 7 — Reflection

A quiet week to notice what already felt manageable, and what you'd want to carry into the weeks ahead.

Breakfast: Whichever breakfast felt best this week — worth repeating.

Lunch: Whichever lunch from this week you'd want again.

Nourishment break: Whichever snack worked best for you this week.

Dinner: Whichever dinner from this week you'd want again.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack, whatever suits you.

Still in Rebuilding. Small, steady sources, chosen consistently, do more for you here than any single perfect meal.

Gentle weekly reflection

Did anything about this week's foods surprise you — anything already a regular part of your meals?

Looking ahead

Next week, we'll look at another nutrient as you continue rebuilding your own strength.

Food safety basics

- Cook eggs, meat, and fish all the way through — no runny yolks or pink centres.
- Cook sprouts before eating them. Raw sprouts carry a real risk of bacteria that washing doesn't remove — skip them raw entirely.
- Choose pasteurized milk, curd, and paneer.
- Wash fruits and vegetables well.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. If the source is uncertain, boil it or use a purifier suitable for the local water risk, and avoid ice from unknown sources when eating out.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding, unless your maternity team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding. If you choose to drink, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose lower-mercury fish and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.